was set for a major confrontation. Along the 38 parallel, skirmishes broke out and on that pretext North Korea invaded South Korea on 25 June 1950. South Korea was battered badly by North Korean forces and its Capital Seoul was conquered by the latter. On the other side of the 38 parallel, substantial Soviet support to North Korea further fuelled US fears of another communist bid to expand further into Asia. So, USA came to the relief of South Korea and it launched a counter-attack from Japan. Matters became worse when Chinese intervention took place in the Korean War.

Simultaneously, USA was successful in moving a resolution in the United Nations Security Council and declared North Korea as an aggressor, and launched a full-fledged offensive against North Korea with the help of UN troops. USA took advantage of the long absence of the Soviet representation in the Security Council, bypassed the Security Council, and passed the Uniting for Peace Resolution (UPR), in 1950. By virtue of UPR, it could take actions even in the absence of Soviet representation. However, with an armistice signed in July 1953, after the death of Stalin there was a cessation of hostility but much damage was done to the relations between the two superpowers.

Further, the detonation of the first Soviet nuclear device in August 1949, also ended the US nuclear monopoly and created a sort of fear in the minds of the Western European states. They now lacked confidence in the United States and also in the Western military strength, and harboured a fear of nuclear attack from Soviet Union.

1953–1959

After the Korean crisis, the Indo-China became the theatre of Cold War tensions between the superpowers. The riding tensions between the French colonial administration and the communist national liberation movement, the Viet Minh was looked at with suspicion by USA. By January 1950, the Soviets and the new regime of China had given diplomatic recognition to the Viet Minh. By 1954, the Viet Minh controlled large tracts of North Vietnam and made its presence felt in the southern part of the country too. Further, to much shock and awe of the Western powers, the communist influence spread from Vietnam to the adjacent areas of Laos and Cambodia .